Backlog Refinement Advisor

Reference Guide

This guide explains what the Backlog Refinement Advisor does, how to set up and run a refinement session, and how to read and act on the assessments Claude produces for each backlog item.

1. PURPOSE & BACKGROUND

THE CORE QUESTION

"Is this backlog item ready to pull into a sprint?"

That is the question this tool is built to answer. It takes each backlog item your team is considering and evaluates it against the Product Backlog Refinement Checklist — 14 criteria across four areas of readiness. Claude performs the assessment and returns a structured result: a Clarity rating, a Refinement rating, a gap analysis across all 14 criteria, and clarifying questions for anything it cannot determine from the information provided.

The app is built around a two-phase model. Items are assessed before the refinement meeting, not during it. The assessment is the input to the meeting — the team uses it to guide discussion and record decisions, rather than spending meeting time reading and interpreting raw backlog items.

What this tool does not do

- It does not replace the team's judgement — Claude's assessment is a structured prompt for discussion, not a final verdict.
- It does not track sprint delivery or compare refinement quality to actual outcomes.
- It does not write acceptance criteria or fix vague items — it identifies gaps and asks the questions the team needs to answer.
- It does not enforce a workflow — outcome tags are recorded by the facilitator based on the team's discussion.

2. GETTING STARTED

Teams

The app supports multiple teams. Each team has its own sessions and assessed items, keeping history separate per group. When you log in you land on the 'Your Teams' page. Click a team card to view its sessions. Create a separate team for each group you facilitate refinement with.

Sessions

Each session represents one refinement meeting. A session moves through three states:

Preparing

You are adding and assessing backlog items before the meeting. Items can be added, edited, or deleted in this state.

In Progress

The session has been started. The team is reviewing items together. The item list is locked — no adding, editing, or deleting.

Complete

All items have been reviewed and tagged with outcomes. The session can be reopened to change outcomes if needed.

Typical workflow

Step 1 Create a session and set the date.

Step 2 Add or import the items you plan to discuss. Claude assesses each one on import.

Step 3 Review the assessment results in the Prepare Session table before the meeting.

Step 4 Click 'Start Session →' when the meeting begins. This locks the item list and opens the team review view.

Step 5 Work through items one at a time with the team. Tag each with an outcome and add notes to capture key discussion points.

Step 6 When all items are tagged, the session completes and the Summary page shows a breakdown of all outcomes.

3. ADDING & IMPORTING ITEMS

Manual add

Click '+ Add Item' to open the manual entry form. Fill in the fields and click 'Run Assessment' — Claude evaluates the item immediately and adds it to the session table.

- Title is the only required field.
- All other fields are optional but directly affect assessment quality. Leaving Acceptance Criteria blank will cause Claude to flag it as a checklist gap.
- An item can be edited after adding — click 'Edit' in the session table. Saving re-runs the Claude assessment with the updated content.

Import from Jira

Click 'Import from Jira' to fetch issues directly from your Jira project using a JQL query. The import follows three steps:

Step 1 Enter a JQL query and click 'Fetch Issues'. Replace the project key placeholder with your own (e.g. project = PAY). Add filters for sprint or issue type to narrow results.

Step 2 Map your Jira fields to the app's six fields. The app detects eligible text fields from the fetched issues and pre-selects likely matches. Review and correct any mismatches. Title must be mapped before proceeding.

Step 3 Select the issues you want to import and click 'Import & Assess Selected'. Claude assesses each selected item on import.

Jira's 'Summary' field is the issue title. If auto-detection maps a different field to Title, correct it manually.

Import from CSV

Click 'Import from CSV' to upload a spreadsheet export from any tool — Jira, Linear, Azure DevOps, or a manual spreadsheet. The import follows three steps:

Step 1 Upload a CSV file. Download the CSV Template if you are starting from scratch — it uses the exact column headers the app expects, so the mapping step is skipped entirely.

Step 2 Map your CSV column headers to the app's six fields. Auto-detection handles common names. Title must be mapped before proceeding.

Step 3 Review the detected rows, select the ones you want to import, and click 'Assess & Import'.

4. UNDERSTANDING THE ASSESSMENT

Each backlog item is assessed by Claude and produces four outputs: a Clarity rating, a Refinement rating, a gap count, and an uncertain count. These appear as columns in the Prepare Session table.

Clarity

Clarity measures how well-written and understandable the item is based on the information provided.

High Clarity

The item has a clear purpose, defined acceptance criteria, sprint-threatening unknowns are resolved, and it is small enough to fit within a sprint.

Moderate Clarity

The team has a rough understanding of the item. It is a likely candidate for refinement soon but some unknowns are still open.

Low Clarity

The item is a rough idea with minimal description. It may change or disappear before it is ever brought into a sprint.

Refinement

Refinement measures how well-scoped the item is — whether it has the right level of detail for sprint planning.

Too Vague

Major unanswered questions remain. There is a high likelihood of surprises mid-sprint. The team cannot commit to this item responsibly.

Ideal

Enough clarity to fit in a sprint. Major risks are addressed. Minor unknowns are acceptable — the goal is confidence, not certainty.

Over-Refined

The item has been specified to an unnecessary level of detail. It reads like a technical specification rather than a backlog item, or it is being refined far in advance of when it will be built.

Gaps and Uncertain

Gaps

The number of checklist criteria Claude identified as clearly not met (marked ✗ in the full assessment). These are confirmed missing elements the team should address.

Uncertain

The number of checklist criteria Claude could not determine from the information given (marked ? in the full assessment). These are not confirmed gaps — they are open questions the team should discuss.

Common Mistakes

If Claude detects one of the five common refinement anti-patterns, an amber callout appears in the item's detail view. These are only flagged when clearly evident from the submission.

- Refining Until Nothing Is Uncertain — pursuing certainty at the cost of delivery
- Refining Too Far Ahead — detailing work that is still months away
- Refining Too Late — items arrive at planning without adequate preparation
- Turning Refinement Into Design — prescribing implementation rather than describing need
- Including Everyone Every Time — involving the full team in every refinement decision

5. RUNNING A SESSION

Click 'Start Session →' from the Prepare Session page to open the team review view. This locks the item list and transitions the session to In Progress.

Navigation

Items are shown one at a time, designed for projector or screen sharing. Use 'Prev' and 'Next' to move through the list, or click any progress dot to jump directly to that item. Each dot shows the current outcome colour when tagged, or remains untagged (grey) until a decision is made.

The assessment display

For each item the team sees: the Clarity and Refinement cards at the top, an overall summary paragraph, the full 14-item checklist in an expandable section, and the Common Mistakes callout if applicable.

- ✓ (green) — this criterion is satisfied. A brief explanation of why it passes is shown indented beneath it.
- ✗ (red) — this criterion is a confirmed gap. Clarifying questions are shown indented beneath it.
- ? (blue) — Claude could not determine whether this criterion is met. Questions are shown to prompt team discussion.

Outcome tags

Tag each item with the team's decision after discussion:

Ready for Sprint

The item is well-defined and can be pulled into the next sprint.

Needs More Refinement

Gaps were identified. The item needs further work before it is sprint-ready.

Return to Product Owner

The item needs clarification or rework from the product owner before it can be refined further.

Defer

The item is not a priority for the current sprint window.

Split Required

The item is too large or complex. It should be broken down into smaller items before being brought back for refinement.

Notes

Add optional notes per item to capture key points raised during the meeting. Notes are saved automatically when you navigate to the next item. They appear in the Session Summary and CSV export.

Any outcome can be changed during the session by returning to that item. The session does not complete until every item has been tagged.

6. SESSION SUMMARY

The Session Summary opens automatically when all items have been tagged, or can be accessed from the navigation bar at any point during the session.

Outcome count bar

A visual breakdown of all five outcome tags for this session. Shows the count per outcome at a glance.

Results table

One row per item showing: item title, Clarity, Refinement, outcome tag, facilitator notes, and the date Claude assessed it.

Export CSV

Downloads the full session results as a spreadsheet. Untagged items export with a status of 'Pending'.

Continue Session →

Returns to Session Review without changing the session status. Available when the session is still In Progress.

Reopen Session

Changes the session status back to In Progress so outcomes can be changed. Available when the session is Complete.

7. THE CHECKLIST

The app evaluates every backlog item against the Product Backlog Refinement Checklist — 14 criteria organised into four groups. Each criterion is marked ✓ (satisfied), ✗ (gap), or ? (uncertain) based on the information provided in the item's fields.

Group 1: Shared Understanding (4 items)

These criteria check whether the team has a common, clear understanding of what the item is and why it exists.

- The team can explain the item in their own words
- The team understands the problem this item is intended to solve
- The team understands what must be true for this item to be considered complete
- The team agrees on what is included and what is not included

Group 2: Acceptance Boundaries (3 items)

These criteria check whether the conditions for completion have been defined and edge cases have been considered.

- The major acceptance criteria have been identified
- Obvious edge cases have been discussed
- The team understands the key assumptions behind this item

Group 3: Size and Sprint Fit (4 items)

These criteria check whether the item is appropriately sized and the team feels equipped to deliver it within a sprint.

- The item is small enough to be completed within a sprint
- If the item is too large, the team knows how it will be split
- The item is comparable in size to work the team has successfully completed before
- The team feels comfortable committing to this item

Group 4: Risks and Unknowns (3 items)

These criteria check whether the risks, dependencies, and uncertainties are understood and manageable.

- Unknowns that could significantly increase scope have been resolved
- Dependencies have been identified
- Remaining uncertainty feels manageable within the sprint

Claude evaluates each criterion based solely on the content of the submitted fields. The more information provided — especially Acceptance Criteria, Dependencies, and Assumptions — the more specific and reliable the assessment will be. A ? result does not mean the criterion is unmet; it means the information given was insufficient to make a determination.

8. WRITING BETTER BACKLOG ITEMS

Claude's assessment quality is directly proportional to the quality of the input. The following guidance applies to each of the six fields.

Title

Be specific enough that anyone reading the title understands the scope without needing to open the description. Avoid generic titles like "Improve performance" or "Bug fix" — these give Claude nothing to evaluate.

Description

Include the user need and the reason the item exists. Frame it around the problem being solved, not the solution. The description should answer: who needs this, what do they need, and why does it matter?

Acceptance Criteria

List the specific conditions that must be true for the item to be considered done. Each criterion should be testable — a reviewer should be able to look at the outcome and confirm pass or fail. Vague criteria like "it should work well" do not satisfy this checklist group. Leaving this field blank is the single most common cause of low Clarity scores.

Dependencies

List anything outside the team's control that must be in place before this item can be completed — other teams, external services, infrastructure, or items in the same sprint. Unidentified dependencies are a primary cause of sprint failures.

Assumptions

State what the team is treating as true without having verified it. Surfacing assumptions explicitly allows Claude to flag them as risks and prompts the team to validate them before committing.

Notes

Use this field for supplementary context that does not fit elsewhere: background on why the item exists, risk observations, decisions made in previous sessions, or links to related discussions. Claude reads Notes as part of the full assessment.

Signs your item needs more work before refinement

- The title could apply to three different features simultaneously
- Acceptance Criteria is blank or contains labels rather than testable conditions (e.g. "Contentful environment" rather than "Contentful Dev environment is configured and accessible from the build pipeline")
- The description explains a technical approach rather than a user need
- No dependencies are listed for an item that integrates with external systems
- The item is an epic or a category of work rather than a single deliverable

9. TIPS & COMMON QUESTIONS

- **An item scores Low Clarity. Does that mean we should not refine it?** Not necessarily. Low Clarity reflects the state of the written item, not whether the underlying idea is valid. It means the item needs more information before Claude — or any reviewer — can meaningfully assess it. Use it as a signal to invest time in writing it up properly before bringing it to a refinement session.
- **An item scores Over-Refined. Is that a problem?** It can be. Over-Refined items have usually had more time spent on them than was productive. Common causes: the item was written by an engineer and reads like a technical specification; or it was refined multiple sessions ago and accumulated detail incrementally. The fix is usually to strip back to the user need and acceptance criteria, and stop there.
- **Claude marked something as ? but the team knows the answer. Does that mean the prompt is wrong?** No. ? means Claude could not determine the answer from the written fields. The information may be in the team's heads rather than in the item. That is a useful finding — it means the item should be updated to capture that knowledge explicitly before the sprint starts.
- **Should we always aim for Ideal refinement?** Yes — but Ideal means enough clarity to commit, not perfect clarity. The checklist explicitly allows minor unknowns. Chasing certainty on every item is itself a common mistake (Refining Until Nothing Is Uncertain). The goal is confidence, not completeness.
- **Can I re-run the assessment after editing an item?** Yes. Click 'Edit' on any item in the Prepare Session table, update the fields, and click 'Save & Re-assess'. Claude runs a fresh assessment with the updated content.
- **What happens to items with no outcome at the end of a session?** Untagged items remain in the session and export with a status of 'Pending'. The session will not automatically complete until all items have been tagged. Use the progress dots to identify which items still need a decision.

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